

The Honey Guide

Tell the real jar from the fake, store it so it lasts a lifetime, and use it the way it was used for centuries.

You watched the 60 seconds. Here is the whole thing. Honey is the one food that, sealed and kept dry, effectively never spoils — its low moisture and natural acidity leave nothing for mold or bacteria to grow in. Archaeologists have found edible honey in tombs thousands of years old. The trick is knowing you have the real thing, and keeping it right.

SPOT REAL RAW HONEY

- **Crystallizing is a good sign** — real raw honey naturally turns grainy and solid over months. Many cut or heavily processed honeys stay perfectly clear and runny forever. Cloudiness and crystals mean it is alive, not spoiled.
 - **Read the label** — look for the single word "raw" and one named country or region of origin. "Blend of honeys from more than one country" and "ultra-filtered" often signal honey that has been cut or stripped.
 - **Watch it pour** — thick raw honey runs slowly off a spoon and folds on itself. Thin, fast, watery honey can be cut with syrup. It is a kitchen rule of thumb, not a lab test, but it rarely lies.
 - **Mind the price and the source** — honey far below the going rate is a warning. When you can, buy from a named local beekeeper or a brand you trust.
-

STORE IT SO IT LASTS FOR LIFE

- **Keep it sealed** — honey draws moisture from the air, and a loose lid can let it ferment over years. A tight jar outlasts everything else in the pantry.
 - **Cool, dark, and never the fridge** — room temperature is ideal; the cold of the fridge only speeds crystallizing.
 - **If it sets hard** — stand the jar in a bowl of warm (not boiling) water and stir gently until it clears. Never microwave or boil it; high heat flattens the flavor and the raw qualities.
-

THE OLD USES

- **In the kitchen** — a long-keeping sweetener for tea, dressings, marinades, and baking, where it also keeps baked goods moist.
 - **A traditional comfort** — a spoonful stirred into warm water with lemon is an age-old soother for a scratchy throat.
 - **A folk skin balm** — for centuries a thin smear was used on dry lips and minor scrapes. Traditional practice, not medical advice.
-

KEEP THIS IN MIND

A jar that has darkened or crystallized is still perfectly good — honey almost never truly spoils. If it ever smells sharp or fermented, moisture got in. Keep the lid tight and one honest jar will outlive every other thing on your shelf.

Keep one honest jar. It is the simplest proof that the old, slow way still beats the fast one. — The Sage

SOURCES National Honey Board (honey.com) · USDA · Smithsonian Magazine, "The Science Behind Honey's Eternal Shelf Life" · Penn State Extension

PURELIVINGZONE